Week 5 Notes: Youth Culture, Television and Gender

Oct 5, 2026 · @Michael J

Rock and roll continued — reconstructed from the Week 5.1 and 5.2 slides. The recording uploaded with these slides is the same Week 4.2 lecture as before, so there is no Week 5 lecture audio here.

The Week's Frame

Week 5 is the story of how the industry **regained control** after first-wave rock 'n' roll. The first wave (Berry, Little Richard, Presley) put the writer, singer and player in one person and sold Black music to an interracial teenage audience. By 1960 that wave had stalled, and three things replaced it:

1. **Television** — *American Bandstand* — becomes the main way teenagers meet music, and it is visual first
2. **Payola** gives Washington a reason to discipline the business, and the punishment lands unevenly
3. **The Brill Building and girl groups** return to the Tin Pan Alley model: songwriters and producers in charge, singers replaceable

The Week 4 lecture predicted this directly. On Chuck Berry versus Tin Pan Alley: *"In a few short years, we return to this mode of song production. We'll talk more about this next week."* This is that week.

The subtitle — **Youth Culture and Gender** — names the two lenses. Youth culture explains the television and payola material (5.1); gender explains the girl groups and who held power over them (5.2).

Music and Visuality

The core claim: "The link between sound and vision was **not invented by MTV** (though music videos have been the most obvious place where sound and image collide)." The slides pair MTV with **MuchMusic**, its Canadian counterpart.

Before MTV, the image already did the selling. Teen magazines show it plainly: *16* ("The Magazine for SMART Girls") with Elvis on the cover and "100 Exciting Pictures!"; *Modern Teen* with "Elvis on the Hot Seat." Fans were buying photographs and gossip about a singer as much as the records. This is the celebrity culture from Week 4, in print.

What a music video is, per the slides:

- **Visual and sonic literacies** — you read it with your eyes and ears at once
- **Texts of excess** — more image, costume and spectacle than a song strictly needs (the slide example is David Bowie, "Ashes to Ashes")
- **Advertisements** — promotional material that accompanies a song

Through the 20th century, the "threat" to youth via music increased as images got stronger. Madonna is the slide example — "Like a Prayer" (burning crosses) and "Human Nature." The point connects to Week 4: Elvis on television and the 1956 press panic are earlier versions of the same thing. Once you can *see* the performer, the moral alarm gets louder.

After MTV

- Digital sonic-visual works: **not permanent**, **convenient and mobile**, **short-form video**
- **Music in video games**

The present-day evidence. The slides use Luminate streaming data to show that visual performance still drives listening:

- **Doechii's** U.S. on-demand streams jump after her *Tiny Desk* performance, then spike again when the original 2019 "Anxiety" goes viral (a short-form video effect), peaking around 53 million weekly streams
- Six other artists (Clipse, Bartees Strange, Katie Gavin, Cass McCombs, Sasha Keable, Yasmin Williams) almost all spike in the **week of their *Tiny Desk* performance**

Tiny Desk is doing what *American Bandstand* did: a performance people watch sends them to buy or stream the record.

Rock 'n' Roll at the End of the 1950s

The slide's own verdict: **"(Not a great time for rock 'n' roll)."**

The "decline" of first-wave rock stars — the slide names three and puts "decline" in quotation marks:

- **Berry**

- **Presley**
- **Richard**

The slides list only the names. The standard explanations, from general music history rather than the slides: Little Richard left rock 'n' roll for religion in 1957; Presley was drafted into the U.S. Army in 1958; Chuck Berry was arrested in 1959 and later imprisoned. None of the three "declined" musically — each was removed by circumstance. That is probably why "decline" sits in quotation marks.

The Day the Music Died — February 3, 1959. A chartered plane crashed near Clear Lake, Iowa, killing **Buddy Holly** (22), **Ritchie Valens** (17), and **J.P. "The Big Bopper" Richardson** (28). The slides show the newspaper front page and the memorial compilation.

Together, these leave a gap at the top of the charts. Week 5's question is **who filled it, and on whose terms.** The answer is television, a careful DJ, and a building full of professional songwriters.

Payola

The word: "pay" + "Victrola" (a record player brand).

Why it happened — pressure on record labels for songs to become hits:

- Records were tested in **"break out" cities** — a hit in one market could spread nationally
- **Promoters paid DJs to feature certain songs**

Scale: the **FTC estimated 250 DJs took payment.**

The crackdown

Date	Event
1959–60	Official intervention into the business and media practices associated with early rock 'n' roll
1960	First court case
May 9, 1960	**Alan Freed indicted for accepting $2,500**
1965	Freed dies

Why this matters for the course. Remember the Week 3.1 definition of the DJ: "an individual who was **jockeying or riding** a record toward success." Payola is that job description monetised. The DJ was always a gatekeeper who chose what got heard; payola made the choosing purchasable.

Note also what the hearings targeted: "the business and media practices **associated with early rock 'n' roll**." The investigation was aimed at rock 'n' roll specifically — which connects it to the 1956 moral panic in the press (Week 4). The music Washington disapproved of became the music whose business got investigated.

Alan Freed versus Dick Clark

The slides set these two side by side on purpose. This comparison is the argument of Week 5.1.

	Alan Freed	Dick Clark
Medium	Radio DJ (*Moon Dog House*, *Rock and Roll Dance Party*)	Television host (*American Bandstand*)
Music	**Popular music by Black artists**	**Teen idols**
Audiences	**Promoted integrated concerts — performers and audiences**	**Virtually all-white audiences**; **cautious of integration on the air**
Payola outcome	**Career ended by the payola scandal**; indicted for $2,500	Survived; **hosted until 1989**

Life magazine on Clark: **"The one man that the committee had always been gunning for was Dick Clark — the biggest disk jockey of all and a symbol, in giant screen, of the whole questionable business."**

Read that quote against the outcome. The committee was "gunning for" Clark, yet Freed is the one destroyed. As the next section shows, Clark's conflicts of interest were *larger* than Freed's — he owned record companies and publishers — but they were structured as business holdings, not cash.

The implication the slides set up (stated here as inference, since there is no lecture recording): the payola crackdown punished the DJ who integrated rock 'n' roll and spared the one who kept it white and safe for television. The "death of rock 'n' roll" in the Week 5.1 topic list — in quotation marks — is partly the death of *Freed's* version of it.

A New Form of Rock 'n' Roll: Teen Pop and *American Bandstand*

"Teen Pop"

- **Pleasing *both* teens and politicians** — "both" is underlined on the slide. Teen pop is the compromise: enough of rock 'n' roll to sell to teenagers, safe enough to survive the hearings
- **Incorporated aspects of rock 'n' roll**
- **Reinstated separate roles: songwriter, instrumentalist, singer** — the Tin Pan Alley division of labour, back after Chuck Berry had collapsed it into one person

***American Bandstand* (1952–1989)**

- Featured the music of **"teen idols"** (Brackett)
- **Teens interviewed about their opinions on music** — the show turned the audience into part of the product

Chubby Checker, "The Twist" (1960)

- **Written by Hank Ballard (1959)** — the famous version is a cover; the original was Ballard's own R&B record, which never reached the same audience
- **No. 1 hit in 1960 and again in 1962**
- The twist dance craze; performed on *The Dick Clark Saturday Night Show*
- A run of songs with "twist" in the title followed in 1962
- Breihan: **"'The Twist' — both the song and the dance — is generally remembered as a flash-in-the-pan fad. But pop music history is built on flash-in-the-pan fads"** (Breihan 20)

The Breihan quote is the one assigned reading cited this week. Its point echoes Brabazon and Week 1: dismissing something as "just a fad" is a high/low judgement, and fads are exactly how popular music moves.

Big Bopper, "Chantilly Lace" (1958) — all about the visual / the televised performance.

The Everly Brothers, "Cathy's Clown" (1960) — introduced on Clark's "Top Ten."

How Clark actually made money

- A **"pre-sold market"** — his audience was already assembled and watching
- **No reliance on cash payola.** Instead, **corporate holdings**:
  - **3 record companies**
  - **6 music publishing houses**

    - **A record pressing plant, a distributing firm, and a management company**
- **Programming and promoting artists he had a stake in**

The Crests, "Sixteen Candles" (1958). Once Clark owned it, **he played it 27 times in 3 months, and it became a hit.**

That is the clearest example in the week. Freed took $2,500 to play records. Clark owned the records, the publishers and the pressing plant, played his own record 27 times on national television — and kept his job for another 29 years. Payola was defined narrowly enough that vertical integration didn't count.

The Brill Building

Broadway and 49th Street, Manhattan — home to music-industry offices and studios (labels, publishing companies, studios). It defined the **style and sound of American songwriting** in its period. Note the geography: Manhattan again, like Tin Pan Alley. The publishing model came back to the same city it started in.

Brill Building *sound* (underlined):

- **Influences: rhythm and blues, Latin music, gospel**
- **Commercial success in the late 50s and early 60s**

Brill Building *approach* (underlined):

- ***Control* of the industry (after first-wave rock 'n' roll)** — "control" is underlined too
- **Replaceable performers**

The slides underline **sound** and **approach** as two separate things to learn. The sound borrows from R&B and gospel; the approach is about who holds power. Don't let the attractive sound hide the business model.

> "A breed of young songwriters combined the youthful energy of rock 'n' roll with the sophisticated harmonic and melodic techniques of earlier popular music to create new forms of soulful, dance-oriented popular music" (Brackett)

Vocal arrangements

- **Call-and-response approach** — from gospel, Ray Charles and the Raelettes
- **Lyrics as dialogue between lead and background vocals**
- Example: **Little Eva, "The Loco-Motion" (1962)**, written by **King and Goffin**

Songwriters — Sonny Bono, Neil Diamond, **Carole King***, **Ellie Greenwich***, Paul Simon, **Phil Spector***. The three asterisks mark the writers whose songs are studied this week.

Singers and musicians — Darlene Love, Liza Minnelli, The Ronettes, The Shangri-Las, The Shirelles, Frankie Valli and The Four Seasons.

Youth connected singers and songwriters. Unlike old Tin Pan Alley, the writers were young themselves — close in age to the audience. The slides call it an **extension of the legacy of 1950s rock 'n' roll**, not a break from it.

Girl Groups

1961–1963: the emergence and success of numerous "girl groups."

Brabazon: the first time that female subjectivity had been widely represented. Recall the Week 1 definition of subjectivity — "the quality of possessing perspectives, experiences, feelings, beliefs, desires, and/or power." Girl group songs are sung from a young woman's point of view about her own feelings and desires. That had not been widely heard before on the pop charts.

The Shirelles, "Will You Love Me Tomorrow" (1960)

- Written by **Carole King and Gerry Goffin**
- **First No. 1 hit by an all-girl group in the U.S.**
- **Girl group *sound*** (underlined): **dense harmonies, expansive orchestra, pensive and evocative lead vocal; double snare on the two**

The song itself is a good case for Brabazon's claim: a young woman asking, before sleeping with someone, whether he'll still love her the next day. Her uncertainty and desire are the subject of the song.

Girl groups outside the Brill Building — the Marvelettes, Martha and the Vandellas, the Supremes, all on **Motown**. The Week 3 lecture promised a return to soul "when we look at a label of a studio like Motown" — these groups are the bridge.

Girl Groups and Feminism — this slide is the critical counterweight to Brabazon:

- **Women are not as visible in the history of popular music**
- **Girl groups as performers *versus* songwriters and producers** ("versus" underlined)
- **"Girl group" refers to singers, not instrumentalists**
  - **Tend to have finite careers**
  - **Part of success is fashion**

Hold both claims together. Girl groups *voiced* female subjectivity for the first time on a mass scale — **and** the women singing usually didn't write the songs, play the instruments, produce the records or control the money. The voice was theirs; the power mostly wasn't. Carole King and Ellie Greenwich are the important exceptions: women on the songwriting side.

The "Production Line" and Phil Spector

The production line (the slide puts it in quotation marks):

- **Singers at the bottom of the hierarchy**
- **Producers could pick from the talent pool of singers — often recorded for very little compensation**

The slide example is **The Raindrops**. The point of showing a group like this: the name on the record and the faces on the cover were a packaging decision. A "group" could be assembled, renamed or invented to fit a song.

Phil Spector

- **One of the most "widely celebrated" figures connected to this genre and era** — "widely celebrated" is in quotation marks on the slide, signalling scepticism
- **(Imbalance of power; economic control)** — the slide's own parenthetical

The slides leave the reason for the scare quotes implicit. For context, from the public record rather than the slides: Ronnie Spector of the Ronettes, whom Spector married, later described his controlling and abusive behaviour, and Spector was convicted of second-degree murder in 2009. Even without that, the slide's point stands on economic grounds alone — Spector controlled the songs, the sound and the money; the singers were interchangeable.

The "Wall of Sound"

- **A dense, reverberant texture filled with instruments that were often difficult to separate from one another**
- **A number of instruments performing the same parts at the same time**
- **Fit for AM radio and jukeboxes**

The last point is the technology theme from Week 1. AM radio and jukebox speakers were small and low-fidelity; a thick, doubled, echo-heavy mix sounded big on them. The sound was designed for the playback device.

Note the shift in who the "artist" is. In Week 4 the artist was the performer (Berry, Little Richard). Here the producer becomes the auteur — people talk about "a Phil Spector record," not "a Ronettes record." The singer's name is on the label; the producer's name is on the sound.

Case Studies: "Be My Baby" and "He's a Rebel"

The Ronettes, "Be My Baby" (1963)

- **Writers: Ellie Greenwich, Jeff Barry, Phil Spector**
- **"Wall of Sound" technique**
- Recorded in **Hollywood (Gold Star Studios)**
- **Additional background vocals: Sonny & Cher, Darlene Love**
- **Distinct drum phrase (Hal Blaine)** — the opening boom, boom-boom, *crack* pattern
- **Use of full orchestra** for texture and layers

Listen for the drum intro first — it's one of the most-copied openings in pop. Then listen for how hard it is to pick out any single instrument once the orchestra comes in. That blur *is* the Wall of Sound.

The Crystals, "He's a Rebel" (1962) — the week's sharpest example:

- **Credited to the Crystals**
- **Actually sung by Darlene Love, recorded by the Blossoms**
- **Produced by Phil Spector**
- **The Wrecking Crew** (session musicians) played on it

The group on the label didn't sing the song. This is "replaceable performers" in its most literal form. The producer owned the name "the Crystals" as a brand and put whichever voice he wanted behind it.

Run it against earlier weeks:

- **Big Mama Thornton** (Week 4): her "Hound Dog" is remembered as Elvis's song
- **Darlene Love**: her voice is remembered as the Crystals'
- **The Wrecking Crew** are the Los Angeles equivalent of the **Nashville A-Team** (Week 3) — anonymous session players behind polished hits

The pattern across the course is the same: the industry decides whose name goes on the work, and that decision often hides the person who actually made it.

How Week 5 Connects Back

Without a recording, the best guide to what matters this week is where it picks up threads the instructor has already stressed. Almost everything here is a return:

Week 5 material	Earlier week	The connection
Brill Building; teen pop "reinstated separate roles"	Week 2 — Tin Pan Alley; Week 4 — Chuck Berry	The collaborative, behind-the-scenes model returns, as the Week 4 lecture said it would
Payola; Freed vs Clark	Week 3.1 — the DJ "riding a record toward success"	The DJ's gatekeeping power, made purchasable — and punished unevenly
Freed's integrated concerts vs Clark's all-white audiences	Week 2 — race and hillbilly categories	Segregation reappears on television
Pleasing "both teens and politicians"	Week 4 — 1956 press moral panic	Teen pop is the industry's answer to the panic
"The Twist"	Week 3 — Ray Charles: "I didn't try to write any jitterbugs or twists"	The dance craze Charles refused to chase
Breihan on "flash-in-the-pan fads"	Week 1 — high vs low culture	Dismissing a fad is a high/low judgement
Girl groups and female subjectivity	Week 1 — Brabazon's definition of subjectivity	The concept, applied
Women not as visible in the history of popular music	Week 2 — Classic Blues; Week 3 — Sister Rosetta Tharpe	Recurring erasure of women
"He's a Rebel" sung by Darlene Love	Week 4 — Big Mama Thornton and "Hound Dog"	Credit going to someone other than the singer
The Wrecking Crew	Week 3 — Nashville A-Team, studio musicians	Anonymous session players
Wall of Sound built for AM radio and jukeboxes	Week 1 — technology theme	Sound designed for the playback device

Week 5 material	Earlier week	The connection
Teen magazines, *Bandstand*, *Tiny Desk*	Week 4 — Elvis on TV, celebrity culture	Seeing the performer drives sales
Motown girl groups	Week 3 — "we'll return to [soul] when we look at… Motown"	The promised return begins

One larger shift to name in an essay. Across Weeks 4–5, control moves **performer → DJ → television host → producer**. Berry and Little Richard were the stars; Freed made them reachable; Clark decided what teenagers saw; Spector decided what records sounded like and who sang them. Each step moves power further from the person singing.

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Visuality	The image side of popular music — magazines, television, video — which sells music alongside sound
Texts of excess	Music videos as spectacle beyond what the song needs
Payola	"Pay" + "Victrola": paying DJs to play particular records
Break-out city	A test market where a record's local success could spread nationally
Teen pop	Post-1959 rock 'n' roll softened to please "both teens and politicians"; restored separate songwriter, instrumentalist and singer roles
Teen idol	A young, safe, television-friendly star, featured on *American Bandstand*
Pre-sold market	Clark's already-assembled television audience, ready to be sold records

Term	Definition
Brill Building	Manhattan office building at Broadway and 49th; centre of late-50s and early-60s professional songwriting
Replaceable performers	The Brill Building approach: singers as interchangeable parts
Girl group	A group of women singers (not instrumentalists), 1961–63 peak
Female subjectivity	A woman's perspective, feelings and desires as the subject of the song (Brabazon)
Production line	Hierarchy with producers at the top and singers at the bottom, often poorly paid
Wall of Sound	Spector's dense, reverberant, doubled-instrument production, built for AM radio and jukeboxes
The Wrecking Crew	Los Angeles session musicians behind many Spector records

Listening List

Track	Artist	Year	Listen for
"Chantilly Lace"	The Big Bopper	1958	A song built around its televised performance
"Sixteen Candles"	The Crests	1958	The record Clark owned and played 27 times in 3 months
"The Twist"	Chubby Checker	1960	The dance craze; No. 1 in 1960 and 1962
"Cathy's Clown"	The Everly Brothers	1960	Introduced on Clark's "Top Ten"
"Will You Love Me Tomorrow"	The Shirelles	1960	First U.S. No. 1 by an all-girl group; dense harmonies, double snare on the two; a woman's point of view

Track	Artist	Year	Listen for
"The Loco-Motion"	Little Eva	1962	Call-and-response between lead and backing vocals; King and Goffin
"He's a Rebel"	"The Crystals" (Darlene Love and the Blossoms)	1962	Credited to one group, sung by another
"Be My Baby"	The Ronettes	1963	Hal Blaine's drum intro; Wall of Sound layering

Self-Check

- [ ] Explain the claim that MTV did not invent the link between sound and vision, with one pre-MTV example
- [ ] Name the three first-wave stars whose "decline" the slides list, and say why "decline" is in quotation marks
- [ ] Define payola and explain how break-out cities made it valuable
- [ ] Compare Alan Freed and Dick Clark on music, audiences and what happened to each after the payola hearings
- [ ] Explain why Clark's corporate holdings were a bigger conflict of interest than Freed's $2,500, and why only Freed was destroyed
- [ ] Explain "pleasing both teens and politicians" and what teen pop reinstated
- [ ] Distinguish the Brill Building *sound* from the Brill Building *approach*
- [ ] State Brabazon's claim about girl groups and female subjectivity, and give the "girl groups and feminism" counter-argument
- [ ] Describe three features of the Wall of Sound and why it suited AM radio
- [ ] Explain what "He's a Rebel" shows about replaceable performers, and connect it to an earlier week
- [ ] Trace the shift of control from performer to DJ to television host to producer across Weeks 4–5

Reconstructed from slides only. If the review sheet names examples from this week that are not here, they came from the lecture.